

The Widow Fen

Monday, 31 August 2026 · plot and bookkeeping: what changed, what is canon, rulings, threads, quotes

The GM's record of the session, spoiler-tolerant: the companion to the player recap. Nothing here was shown to the players.

Spoiler-tolerant. Companion to recap.md and combat-stats.md.

Plan vs. table — what actually happened

PLANNED	RAN
Swamp fight as a teaching encounter, "Low-to-Moderate"	Near-TPK. One <i>Vitriolic Sphere</i> did 198 damage and dropped 2 of 4 PCs
Treetop romp, 30–45 min with small fights	Ran roughly to plan; 5 one-round fights, 6 damage taken total
Masie gambit, illusion worked by invisible Mabel	✓ Landed. Broken by Morgash, not by an Insight roll
Long parley at the tea table, metered truth, two standing offers	Compressed to ~7 minutes. Hazel called it off and went to violence
Fight to the death if talk fails	✓ Happened, and was one-sided — 2 rounds
Homecoming + Dream A.2	Did not reach it. Ended at the town line

The parley was much shorter than planned. The quote bank barely got used: no Ethel name-drop in Mabel's voice, no Lae'zel mimicry beat, no shard-tax recitation, no "a heart has FOUR" line from a hag, and **the Morgash bargain (cut the heartbreak out, bottled, taken in payment) was never offered.** The scene went delight → the Lae'zel jab → the partnership pitch → the unbreakable-bond demand → Hazel's patience running out. Worth knowing that the pitch itself landed; it was the *terms* that broke it. Thomas was ready to sign.

Balance — the swamp needs a look before you reuse it

The Bog Sage out-damaged everything else in the session by a wide margin. It dealt **198** of the **219** total damage the party took across the whole night. A CR-4 caster with a 4th-level 20-ft-radius AoE against a clustered level-5 party at the *first* encounter of the night is a coin-flip on a TPK, and the DM said so at the table: *"I don't understand why they gave bog sages that spell."* Options if the statblock comes back: drop the slot level, give it a smaller radius, or don't open the session with it.

Contrast: the actual **boss fight was trivial** — the hags at 86 HP died in 2 rounds having dealt 23 damage between them. The difficulty curve ran exactly backwards.

Loose threads and hooks

- **THE NAME.** Thomas's whole arc now hangs on a name the hags claimed to have and died holding. The jar-wall explicitly has no procurer name. Decide where the name actually lives — a second ledger in the fen they never searched? Someone in Daggerford? A Greenrest connection? The players will come looking, and Thomas said out loud that this is why he's on the quest.
- **The gilt-framed portrait of a stern merchant** (renamed "...of a Smiling Merchant" 2026-09-06 with new DM art + description; the party snapshot keeps the as-played name) — pure flavor loot, but Jetten decided unprompted that it might be someone Greenrest would recognize, and Thomas asked *"Not Applewhite, is it?"* Free gift: make it someone. It costs nothing and they've already invested.
- **The dryad is now public knowledge to the party** — trapped under the Greenrest tree, through her own grief, older than the hags, and the Heart is hers. They walked into town knowing this. The tree-budding beat lands differently now: they will read it as a count, exactly as intended.
- **The Morgash bargain is unspent** — no hag ever offered to bottle his heartbreak. It can move to another hag, another fey, or come back through Ethel's memory. Don't lose it.
- **"Ours" — the empty jar** was never found (the party missed that room's item or it never came up). Still available.
- **Volo's Guide (Annotated)** was looted but never read aloud at the table — the three-hands easter egg didn't land. Worth a nudge if anyone opens it.
- **Lae'zel** is now firmly on the board for Anthony: the sketches, the teahouse keepsake, and the DM's confirmation that she killed a hag at a riverside teahouse near Baldur's Gate. Morgash played it wistful rather than wounded ("that woman was awesome"), which is a different read than the plan assumed. Follow his lead.

Bookkeeping to apply

- ☑ Party stash: Tideheart + ~3,100 gp of fen valuables + all plot loot — **already in.**
- ☑ Morgash attuned to Graveheart + Periapt + Maul (done at the top of session).
- ☑ Thomas's 2nd-level paladin spells added; he prepared and used **Aid** the same night.
- ☐ **The Tideheart is unattuned and unclaimed.** All four PCs are at 3/3 attunement, so someone has to drop something. The table deferred this to next session — it will be the first thing they ask about.
- ☑ Cleared the lingering *Aid* "Level 2: +5 Max HP" effects (Thomas, Jetten, Morgash), plus Gren's stale *Mage Armor* / *Innate Sorcery* / *Hold Person* concentration — 2026-09-01.
- ☐ Gren has a duplicate *Magic Missile* entry on his sheet.
- ☐ Bestiary pages owed: Enthralled Bullywug Warrior / Bog Sage, Green Hag (Hazel & Mabel), Animated Broom / Flying Sword / Rug of Smothering / Armor. Plus the still-owed Peryton/Longshadow page from session 5.
- ☑ Session Diary journal page: "Session 6 — The Widow Fen" — **live on molten5e** (qcjngmMdVLFrhoJJ), player-visible. The shorter **What You Know** journal also got a new page "6 · The Widow Fen" (wweBdbzhGQYeDQHY) and its "What You Carry, What Waits" page (ULjgWHXDq3r5KpOF) was refreshed to two shards.

Quotes of the night

- **Hazel**, refusing quarter: *"You just killed my sister. Do you think I'm going to make any deal with you? I'd rather die."*

- **Hazel**, to Morgash, at the end: *"Do it. I have nothing to live for."* (and spits)
- **The hags**, on the offer: *"Resurrect the world for all we care. We just need our sister."*
- **Hazel**, on Thomas's oath: *"The oath of a vengeance paladin means nothing to me."*
- **"Masie,"** sniffing Morgash: *"I smell Lae'zel on you."*
- **Gren**, after Fireball: *"I look at Hazel and say — I did not forget any of my spells. Ask the squirrels about my reputation."*
- **Morgash**, to a fleeing Mabel: *"No matter where you go, I'm going to find you."*
- **Thomas**, holding the jar: *"How's that not my wife's finger in the jar?"* — **Gren**: *"These are adult teeth. I don't think you have anything to worry about."*
- **Thomas**, on the ledger: *"This is exactly why I'm on this quest."*
- **Morgash**, on Lae'zel, twice in one minute: *"I'm going to kill him."* → *"That woman was awesome."*
- **Jetten**, mid-swamp: *"Well, we're almost dead in this round. We might not make it to the hags."*
- **The DM**, signing off: *"I can't believe the first encounter almost killed you, but the hags were a stop."*

GM-only. Compiled from the transcript, the chat log and the live sheets by the session scribe.